COACHING MODULE



SELBORNE COLLEGE RUGBY CLUB

Module 2:

Team Dynamics
Coaching Philosophy
Practices
Player Profiling and Selection
(iRB newsletter)

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TEAM DYNAMICS

"Winning over your team?"

First Meeting

Setting out the criteria:

- Player conduct, discipline and punctuality!
- A great way of coming up with the rules for the team is to let the players come up with their own rules and standards.
- What fitness levels are expected etc?

Work out team goals and what will be needed to achieve them:

- Don't interrupt the brain storming process the team needs to come up with there own ideas.
- These goals can be used as a motivational tool during the season.
- Pick seven of the most important ones. These can be used as evaluations.

Present the team with your goals as the coach:

- This will give the team a good idea of where you are coming from.
- Fair, honest, approachable, etc.
- Share your philosophy about the game.

Coach's Relationship with the Team

"Respect is something earned and not expected"

Individual:

- Learn everyone's names and call them by their Christian name.
- Find out what their preferred positions are and tell them where you want to use them.
- Find out their individual goals.
- Be **HONEST** and let them know exactly where they stand at all times.
- Treat everyone the same.
- Never break a player down negatively and try not to single him out in front of everyone.
- Be constructive with your criticism and continually build your players up.
- You must be approachable and setting up individual times to work with players can be beneficial.

Team:

- Your relations with the individual set the atmosphere for working with the team.
- The team must know everyone's names and need to learn to get on. Any arguing and fighting amongst players is forbidden, this must be stressed.
- No negativity and talking behind player's backs. This breaks a team down.
- Constantly remind them of their team goals and what they have said is needed to achieve them. This is a good motivational technique.
- Take notice of which players seem to stick together and keep mixing them up with the rest of the team.
- Try to make things fun and enjoyable for the team. You must strive to create an environment of the players wanting to practice.

Evaluating Players' Strengths and Weaknesses

"Aiming high and working at it"

A useful exercise like evaluating the players' strengths and weaknesses can be used during the season to improve the team. The players get to evaluate one another on their strengths and weaknesses. This will give the coach feedback and ideas on what may need improving. You will be surprised to see what comes up. You may not have realised some things about certain players.

If you can concentrate on improving the individual weaknesses of your players the team should improve.

Be wary of how you give the feedback back to the players and stress that they are confidential and do not need to be discussed amongst them. Ensure that nothing gets personal. Players need to understand their own STRENGTHS and WEAKNESSES and must have an appreciation of those of their team-mates. Every player wants to improve and don't be embarrassed if you have to call in outside help to help coach them. As a coach, you are never going to know everything.

Coaching Tip:

Give the player two strengths and one weakness to work on.

Strengths and Weaknesses Exercise

Name: _____

Strengths:

_____
_____
_____
_____
_____

Weaknesses:

_____
_____
_____
_____
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Name: _____

Strengths:

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Weaknesses:

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Name: _____

Strengths:

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Weaknesses:

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What makes a successful team?

"It is better to die on your feet than stay on your knees!"

A team is a small number of people with complementary skills who are committed to:

- A common purpose
- A set of performance goals
- An approach for which they hold themselves mutually accountable

Achieving the task

Teams develop **Direction**, **Momentum** and **Commitment** by working together to shape a meaningful purpose.

The expectations of the team need to be broadly framed by all role players. Team management must leave enough flexibility for the team to set specific goals.

Building the team

- Share leadership roles
- Individual and mutual accountability
- Specific team purpose that the team delivers
- Continual improvement by reviewing performance against best practice

Individual needs

- All members of the team need responsibilities and roles
- They need guidance and up skilling to perform at a higher level
- They need to **BUY IN** to achieving the common task and objectives
- Acknowledge effort and non performance

The Coach is the Go to Man

"The coach must be a leader and a follower"

- Makes the hard decisions
- Always demands the player's best
- Is passionate about the game
- Puts the **TEAM** first

Maintaining the Team

"Don't kid yourself and never let down your mates"

No group ever becomes a team until it can hold itself accountable as a team.

Think of the difference between the following statements:

[1] "The coach holds me accountable" or

[2] "We hold ourselves accountable"

The first sentence can lead to the second, but without the second there can be no team. Team accountability is about the sincere promise that we make to ourselves and others which underpin two critical aspects that affect a team.

- **TRUST & COMMITMENT**

The sense of mutual accountability also produces the rich rewards of achievement that all members share.

Buck's Coaching Checklist

	KEY FUNCTIONS	TASK	TEAM	INDIVIDUAL
COMMUNICATION	**DEFINE OBJECTIVE**	Identify tasks & constraints	Communicate with team Identify problems	Clarify aims Gain acceptance
	PLAN	Establish priorities Decide who is involved Check resources	Generate ideas Evaluate(trial) Select a solution and draw up a plan	Assess/use skill Define roles Involve appropriate individuals
	BRIEF Inform / Confirm	Brief group & check their understanding	Summarise the plan Allocate tasks Answer questions Obtain feedback	Delegate Listen Enthuse Encourage
	IMPLEMENT Monitor & Support	Monitor progress Maintain standards Discipline Adapt plan if required	Co-ordinate and support the team Reconcile conflict	Assist/Reassure Recognise effort Counsel
	EVALUATE	Summarise progress Review objectives Replan if necessary	Recognise success Learn from failure	Assess performance Appraise Guide and train

What makes a Good Team?

- It acknowledges the **past**.
- **Players** are in a secure, stable environment working at our various tasks and levels.
- Shoulders straighten and we display pride and **self-belief**.
- There is a feeling of **belonging** in a team.
- Coaches and management initiate and execute a planned programme based on **success** knowing that the player is more important than the detail.
- There are **no favourites**.
- Our **mentoring** of players' progress is positive, regular, perceptive, objective, accurate and involves the player.
- In this concept there are **no failures**. Tasks are being set and players are encouraged to extend themselves.
- Some of us take longer to learn things; some need to be exposed to the same things more often for **mastery** to occur.
- We need to keep on finding the means and methods which make **improvement** possible for each of us.

In a Good Team

"Together we'll back ourselves"

- We **talk** to one another about what we do.
- These conversations are frequent, continuous, concrete and precise.
- We **observe** each other in our preparation, practice and playing. These observations become the practice to talk about and reflect on.
- We **work together**. Planning, practising, playing and reviewing.
- We **help** each other; teach the things we know.

In these ways a **good team** will:

- Reveal ourselves in our **CRAFT**
- **ARTICULATE** what we do
- **SHARE**
- Continue, persistently, vigorously, tenaciously, practically to become **GOOD – BETTER – BEST**
- We have **STANDARDS!**

These things make a good team **tough**.

A good tough team is hungry and excited in pursuit of a goal greater than the individual.

In this team we will:

- Fashion our own direction
- Find our own place… **TOGETHER**

The Captain

"A captain is only as good as the team he leads"

The coach should appoint the Captain. It should preferably not be done via a vote by the players.

Key Characteristics:

- Great understanding of the game
- Leadership qualities
- Loyal and honest
- Consistent performer

The Captain and the Referee Relationship

"Take the Referee out of the equation"

There is a fine line between:

CHALLENGE VS DEBATE

- The captain needs to earn respect and the right to challenge.
- Never debate with the referee.
- Always agree and note, then challenge.

Coaching Tip:

It is a great idea to only focus on two areas of the game, which are brought to the attention of the referee before the match e.g. "we have been working hard at attacking the oppositions ball could you please let us have a fair contest?" and "we are wanting fast ball today especially from the ruck could you watch the tackler?"
These points can be brought up during dialogue with the ref during the game after agreeing with the refs' decision.

"Has a ref ever changed his decision before?"

COACHING PHILOSOPHY

"You will be surprised how much you can achieve when you do your best"

Every coach should have their own coaching philosophy. This philosophy is a set of values and beliefs that govern your actions. It would stay the same for any level of coaching you may do.

As an example I would like to share my own coaching philosophy:

- Attack: Attack into the spaces to score more points than the opposition
- Defence: Apply pressure to regain possession

General Points

"I want this team to play every minute to the best of its ability and score more points than the opposition" Tony Gilbert

- Get the ball
- Go forward
- Support the ball carrier
- Maintain continuity
- Turn pressure into points

PRACTICES

"Practice does not make perfect, perfect practice makes perfect!"

- It is crucial to keep the enjoyment in practices.
- Need to be consistent with the structure of your practice as well as your warm up before matches.
- Practice less at higher intensity than draw it out (Maximum 1hr30).
- Stick to practice times and never go over the time. This means that you will have to plan practises cleverly in advance.
- Never have a practice unprepared. There is nothing worse than a player who gives up his time to come to a practice that is a waste of his time.
- After a practice, the players must feel happy with themselves - that they have achieved something constructive.

Practice Structure

10 min: Warm up with supporting calls and stretch in between
30 min: Games and Drills
20 min: Split: Forwards – Scrumming and Line outs
Backs – Moves
15 min: Shadow: Game plan and plays e.g. Kick offs etc. or Aerobic activity
15 min: Warm down

Coaching Tip:

It is a good idea to do speed work at the beginning of the practice during the warm up.

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Player Profiling and Selection

Lee Smith

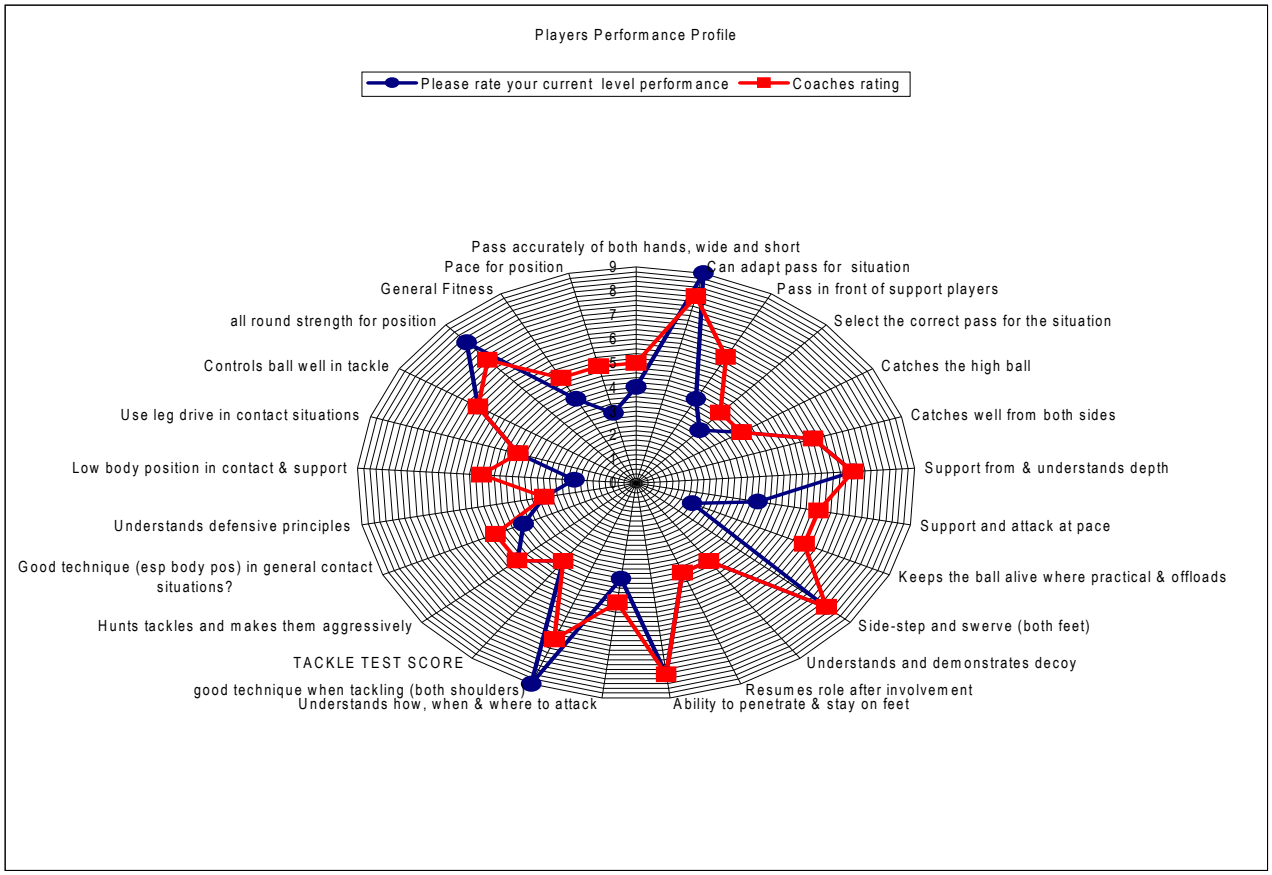
Performance Profile

The Performance Profile is a snapshot of a player's current self-perception. Coaches can use profiling to help them understand a performer's perceptions of his/her strengths and weaknesses. A properly completed profile can provide a base from which coach/player development plans can be built.

How to use the profile

Playing Component	Please rate your current level performance	Coaches rating	Notes
Pass accurately of both hands, wide and short	4		
Can adapt pass for situation	9		
Pass in front of support players	4		
Select the correct pass for the situation	3		
Catches the high ball	4		
Catches well from both sides	6		
Support from & understands depth	7		
Support and attack at pace	4		
Keeps the ball alive where practical & offloads	2		
Side-step and swerve (both feet)	8		
Understands and demonstrates decoy	4		
Resumes role after involvement	4		
Ability to penetrate & stay on feet	8		
Understands how, when & where to attack	4		
good technique when tackling (both shoulders)	9		
TACKLE TEST SCORE	4		
Hunts tackles and makes them aggressively	5		
Good technique (esp body pos) in general contact situations?	4		
Understands defensive principles	3		
Low body position in contact & support	2		
Use leg drive in contact situations	4		
Controls ball well in tackle	6		
all round strength for position	8		
General Fitness	4		
Pace for position	3		

1. First identify the key playing components. This can be done by the coach, but I believe it is important to have the input of the player. Remember with the modern game we are looking at the "complete rugby player", but there are positions with unique aspects of the game.
2. Clarify the meaning of each component, saves misuderstanding.
3. Self-rating of current performance in each area against a perfect performance. Make the player understand they are setting themselves against the perfect player. Marks between 1-10.
4. The scores are then plotted on the chart, this provides a concrete depiction of the players self-perception. (BLUE)
5. The coach then will fill in his/her scores for the performer.(RED) There <u>will</u> differences, but this can be used to increase the players confidence and also let them know where they need to improve. It is a tool that may be used to generate a shared understandings of self-concepts and priorities.



6. The completed profile grows, changes shape and changes constantly as the player develops. The changing profile of the coach should be recorded in a player's portfolio. Profiling should be attempted when the coach believes there will be significant differences between the previous chart and the current one.
7. The profile is used for development planning because the goals set and the time-scales outlined are based on a framework with which the player can identify. The areas prioritised will be those the coach and player has identified. The whole process will be relevant to the player, who therefore far more likely to adhere to it.

SELECTION METHODS

Introduction

- Ultimately whether to select or not select a player is based on the selectors subjective judgment, the selector's "gut" reaction and instinct.

- However, this judgment is based on a feeling for the way the player plays. It should therefore be the last criteria for selection and not the first.

- Prior to making this final judgment, an objective selection process can be used. This process involves a step-by-step method of selection that is systematic and comprehensive.

- This method will ensure that when the final choice is made it is based on sound objectivity to the stage at which the final subjective selection is made.

Selecting Proactively or Selecting Reactively

Before the Selection Method is described, the distinction between selecting proactively and selecting reactively will be explained.

Proactive Selection

When a team is selected proactively it is selected to meet the requirement of an ideal game plan i.e. the way the Game should ideally be played. So the process would be to develop the ideal Game Plan and Patterns of Play and select the best available talent to play to it.

Reactive Selection

When a team is selected reactively, the first step is to develop a profile of the talents of the players that are available. While this is not a profile of a specific team the process is the same.

Once the profile has been developed its strengths and weaknesses will enable a Game Plan, Patterns of Play and Tactics to be developed.

Experience shows that in most, if not all situations, the reactive approach is the one most often followed by selectors and coaches. This is because the talent that is available to most has its strengths and weaknesses. In all situations the strengths and weaknesses are relative. They depend on the strengths and weaknesses of the opposition. There are few teams who cannot afford to take this into account when they are preparing for a match.

It would be reasonable to say that if a team is able to play proactively, to an ideal plan, then it is probably playing against very poor opponents. The team should probably be playing at a higher level, if there is one.

Game Plans that are often looked on as being proactive are more often reactive. Having observed the play of their opponents a team changes its Game Plan to exploit strengths and avoid its weaknesses. Of course both strengths and weaknesses are relative to those of the opposing team. Consequently the method of selection that will be explained will be one that is based on a reactive approach not a proactive approach. It is more realistic.

The Selection Method

The steps that should be followed when selecting a team will first be listed. Following this each step will be explained in turn.

The selection method is based on the following steps:

Step One - Team Profile

Step Two - Game Plan

Step Three - Positional Requirements

Step Four - Analysis of Players

Step Five - Selection Responsibilities

Step Six - Observing Games

Step Seven - Selection Meetings

Step Eight - Co-ordination and Consistency

Step Nine - Attitude

Step Ten - Intuition

Step One

Team Profile

The use of the word “team” is misleading because the profile includes all the playing talent that is available. However, because the processes of developing a profile is the same as that used in the Game Planning Course the term Team Profile will be used

From the total pool of players available the Principles of Play are used to categorise strengths and weaknesses. The following Team Profile Analysis Form is used for this purpose. Implied is a knowledge of the strengths and weaknesses of the individual players who are available.

This knowledge shall be written down in a profile for each player i.e. each players strengths and weaknesses. The profile should be as detailed as possible. Time spent on details in these first steps will ensure that the conclusions arrived at in later steps are accurate.

The Player Profile form should be dated so that comparisons can be made with profiles at various times during a player’s career. The form can also be the basis of an interview with a player when discussing the players training programme.

TEAM PROFILE ANALYSIS FORM

Principle of Play	Strengths	Weaknesses
ATTACK		
1. Gaining Possession		
2. Going Forward		
3. Supporting		
4. Maintaining Continuity		
5. Pressure		
DEFENCE		
1. Contesting Possession		
2. Going Forward		
3. Applying Pressure		
4. Preventing Territory Being Gained		
5. Supporting		
6. Regaining Possession		
7. Counter Attack		

PLAYER PROFILE FORM

Date : ___ / ___/ ___

Name: _____

Positions (in rank order)

(1) : _____ ***(2) :*** _____

(3) : _____ ***(4) :*** _____

Age (as at ___ / ___/ ___) ____ yrs
Date of Birth : ___ / ___ / ___

Playing Record:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Principles of Play	**Strengths**	**Weaknesses**
<u>Attack</u> 1. Gaining Possession		
2. Going Forward		
3. Supporting		
4. Maintaining Continuity (Rucks & Mauls)		
5. Pressure		
<u>Defence</u> 1. Contesting Possession		
2. Going Forward		

3. Applying Pressure (Incl Tackling)		
4. Preventing Territory Being Gained		
5. Supporting		
6. Regaining Possession		
7. Counter Attack		

TEAM PROFILE

Principle of Play	Strengths	Weaknesses
ATTACK		
1. Gaining Possession	*Lineout* - tall players with good hand to eye co-ordination. *Scrums* - a wide range of props, hookers and locks with sound technique and the physical requirements needed. *Kick-Offs* - accurate kickers, catchers able to gain possession. Support players and catchers well co-ordinated.	Level of fitness to sustain their effort throughout a match. Fitness to sustain the effort. Slow to adapt to the kick of strategies of other teams.
2. Going Forward	Rolling maul effective. Able to break the gain line around the source of possession. Average to good kicking skills.	Poor passing skills in the backline. Players tend to drift across the field when they are running with the ball.
3. Supporting	Players available in numbers close to the source of possession.	Ball carriers tend to go far and get isolated. Support poor beyond # 12 caused by the ball carrier moving away from support and the support being slow.
4. Maintaining Continuity	Delivery from rucks and mauls close to the source of possession reliable.	Delivery often too slow from a stationary platform. Speed to the breakdown very slow and disorganised beyond # 12.
5. Pressure	Goal kicker capable of kicking 75% of goal kicks from 45 metres. Beyond this 40 - 50% success. Tries usually from driving forward play.	Over-commit themselves inside the opposing teams 22 metre area which leads to turnovers. Backs have difficulty penetrating. Not good at maintaining field position.
DEFENCE		
1. Contesting Possession	See Gaining Possession above	

2. Going Forward	Play to a pattern.	Over-commit and are easily outflanked by a team that gives itself some space.
3. Applying Pressure	In a position to field kicks. Play to a pattern.	
4. Preventing Territory Being Gained	Strong tacklers.	Line of running too direct, tackle can be too easily evaded.
5. Supporting	Working together to regain possession close to the source of possession.	Defence in numbers beyond # 12.
4. Regain Possession	Counter attack by kicking and chasing.	No counter-attack pattern using passing and running options.
5. Counter Attack		

Step Two

Game Plan

Once the Team Profile is completed the Game Plan can be written. The Principles of Play are used so that the Game Plan has consistency with the Team Profile. Selection will now be based on achieving the Game Plan.

As explained in the Game Planning Manual there will be an attacking Game Plan and a defensive Game Plan. Both can be further sub-divided based on field position and / or the positioning of the opposing players.

The Game Plan (what is to be achieved) can now be used to develop Patterns of Play and Tactics, both of which explain how the Game Plan is to be achieved. These provide the selectors with the criteria for selection that they will use when observing players.

Implied in the Game Plan are the strengths and weaknesses of opposing teams. While these are important, it is important to be positive. The Game Plan and the Patterns of Play explain what and how the team will achieve its aims throughout the season. They are, therefore, what the team is aiming to achieve throughout its matches. Weaknesses should not be dwelled upon. Teams should enter matches aiming to do what they do best.

If so much emphasis is placed on the strengths and weaknesses of individual teams, the team will not develop its own style of play. In these circumstances each match will be a “one-off” situation in which a team finds itself continually changing in reaction to opponents.

The aim should be to develop a proactive Game Plan and proactive Patterns of Play that a team imposes positively on opponents. Tactical changes are a change of emphasis within the Patterns of Play rather than playing to a different Pattern of Play for each match.

EXAMPLE OF ATTACKING GAME PLANS

PRINCIPLES OF PLAY	EXAMPLE (1) ZONES: GOAL LINE TO 22 METRE LINE	EXAMPLE (2) LANES: BETWEEN THE TOUCHLINE AND 15 METRE LINE	EXAMPLE (3) POSITION OF OPPONENTS AT A MID-FIELD SCRUM
Gaining Possession	Clean delivery of the ball to the half back from a forward moving scrum, ruck, maul or lineout.	Controlled delivery from all sources of possession, driving froward to commit their forwards.	Controlled delivery going forward.
Going Forward	Kick the ball to touch as far down the field as possible.	Use running and passing options beyond #13 to exploit the space that is available (within 15m lines).	Use the loose forwards and the backs to create more attackers than defenders by going left to right.
Supporting	Close support to ensure clean delivery. Position to offer more than one kicking option for the halfback.	Backing up to keep the move going.	Backing up once the initial roles have been completed.
Maintaining Continuity	Unimportant as it is more important to be further down the field.	If play has been stopped phase possession to be used to prevent the defence from regrouping. Pass in the same direction again.	If play has been stopped control the delivery, while still going forward, to create space.
Pressure	Avoid opponents defensive pressure by controlling the ball and finding touch.	Maintain pressure by retaining possession and avoiding stoppages.	Maintain pressure by retaining possession and avoiding stoppages.

Defensive Game Plans

Defensive Game Plans may be based on similar sub-divisions however experience has shown different.

The defensive Game Plan throughout the length of the field has just two outcome goals to prevent the opposition from gaining territory and to regain possession of the ball.

These two outcome goals enable the players to focus on something simple but effective. How it is achieved is the next step and to practice it so that it is effective is the final step in preparation for a match.

Step Three

Positional Requirements

Once the selectors have a Game Plan they can take each position and list the positional requirements needed to achieve it.

Positional Requirements

Listed below are the positional requirements for each position.
The positional requirements listed are not for a specific Game Plan, they are a checklist for selection that can be modified to suit the Game Plan that has been developed.

Props:

Tight-Head Prop

Scrums:

- ❏ "Call" the scrum into engagement with the opposition.
- ❏ "Lead in" by being the first member of the front row to contact the opposing front row on your "put in".
- ❏ Stabilise the scrum when the ball is put in on the loose-head so that the ball is delivered from a stable platform.

Lineouts (No. 3 Position in the Lineout):

- ❏ Take up the same stance in the lineout no matter where the ball is thrown to.
- ❏ Stand square-on to the opposition with the outside leg slightly ahead of the inside leg to the opposition. This minimises body movement when supporting the catchers.
- ❏ As the catcher moves to the centre to jump and catch the ball move in unison, so that the support play prevents opponents making contact.
- ❏ Assist the catcher to jump higher and to stabilise the jumper at maximum height until the ball is caught.
- ❏ Once the ball has been caught make sure the catcher lands in a stable position, back on to opponents.
- ❏ Hold the line to provide a protective screen when the ball is not thrown to

#2 and # 4 jumpers.

❑ Alter positioning to ensure protected delivery of the ball (back on) or to contribute to the drive (front on).

Field Play:

❑ Decide on the best role to ensure a clean ball is won to continue play when approaching phase play.

❑ Rucks - options when the team is in possession are :

- Bind and drive past the ball
- Bind on the side to protect the delivery of the ball to the halfback or other distributors.

❑ Rucks - options when the opposing team is in possession are :

- Drive forward to slow down or stop their drive and to slow their delivery of the ball.
- Pack on the side of the ruck and perform the defensive scrum role of a flanker
- Join the defensive screen to tackle a designated ball carrier.

❑ Mauls - options when the team in possession are :

- Bind on the side to protect the delivery of the ball to the halfback.
- Act as the pivot for a rolling maul after initially binding and driving forward.

❑ Mauls - options when the opposing team is in possession are :

- Drive forward to slow down or stop their drive and to slow their delivery of the ball.
- Stop the rolling maul by driving onto the side towards which the maul is rolling.
- Stop the rolling maul by allowing it to roll towards the near touchline and then driving it into touch.

❑ In Defence at all times be aware that backs could cut back against the initial flow of play. Be prepared to tackle the ball carrier.

Loose-Head Prop

Only **additional requirements** to those listed for tight-head props are mentioned below.

Scrums :

- ❑ Bind tightly with the hooker so that the hooker is as close as possible to the ball about to be put into the scrum and to prevent the hooker and prop being "split". Do not bind so tightly that it becomes difficult and uncomfortable for the lock to push effectively.

- ❑ On the put-in, drive slightly upward to open up the tunnel, letting the hooker have an unimpeded strike at the ball.

- ❑ Reach as far forward as comfortable with the outside arm upon engagement. Transfer the opposing tight-head's weight to the area between the shoulder blades.

Lineouts (No. 1 Position in the Lineout) :

- ❑ Assume the same stance for all lineouts. This will be difficult if the player is used as a catcher as well as a supporting player.

- ❑ Develop catching options: Amongst these options are:

    - To catch a fast, flat throw.
    - To catch a back lob which the player takes moving backwards after feinting to go forward.
    - To deflect the ball directly from the top of the jump to the halfback.

- ❑ Become the receiver of the ball from a deflected catch at the end of the lineout. If there is a gap in their lineout penetrate and link with team mates. Aim to go past the advantage line before looking for other options.

  N.B. This player is seldom used in a catching role at lineout, however, if mis-matches eliminate other options, throws to the "taller" prop can enable the team to gain possession.

- ❑ Be alert to catch "bobbled" or deliberately deflected ball so that it is recovered cleanly using two hands. Attempt to recover this ball without leaving the line of touch to prevent opponents breaking through the formation.

Field Play :

- ❑ Use the advantage of having only one shoulder bound in scrums to make a fast "get away" in a supporting role. This must not be done before scrummaging responsibilities have been completed.

Hooker

Scrums :

- ❏ Make your first priority to win ball on the loose head.
- ❏ Choose options on the tight-head so that they are of greatest tactical value and catch the opposition by surprise.
- ❏ Exert tactical and physical pressure on the opposing hooker at all scrums.

Lineouts :

- ❏ Know the throw-in requirements of the lineout forwards and perfect them.
- ❏ Stand in a position that enables maximum protection for the halfback from deflected ball. Mark the opposing hooker closely.
- ❏ Take up a position that enables an unimpeded line to the opposing team's deflected ball.
- ❏ Exploit the general play situation that often occurs when the ball is deflected. This occurs in the time between the conclusion of the lineout and the formation of a phase play.
- ❏ Hookers may be used to support catchers on the opposing teams throw.
- ❏ Because hookers are not bound into the lineout they can enter general play very quickly.

Field Play :

- ❏ From scrums the options are the same as for the other members of the front row.
- ❏ As the player may be the last to leave scrums it is very important to assess the options.
- ❏ Depending on the hooker's skills and speed the player may join the back attack, usually on the blind side.

Locks

Scrums :

- ❏ Bind to each other and to the front row so as to be in a good pushing position once the opposing scrum is engaged.
- ❏ Once contact is made do not alter foot positions.
- ❏ Maintain a stable scrum on the put-in. On the opposing team's put-in, push forward to disrupt the delivery of the ball.

Lineouts (No. 2 and No. 4 catchers) :

- ❏ Initiate both the support and the throw by stepping to the line of touch and leaping vertically to catch the ball.
- ❏ Drive up with the arms to gain maximum height.
- ❏ Watch the ball into the hands.
- ❏ Once the ball has been caught move it immediately away from the opposing players turning the body to follow the ball.
- ❏ Land in a stable body position back-on to opponents.
- ❏ Hold the ball low. It is the target for driving support players. If it is held high they will be too high in their body position to drive effectively.
- ❏ Deliver the ball based on the team's proposed pattern of attack.

Field Play :

- ❏ Move quickly towards the anticipated position of the ball.
- ❏ Bind and drive into rucks and mauls to push them forward.
- ❏ If the opposing players have not been committed to the ruck or maul and the ball is available, drive forward with it in hand.
- ❏ Be aware of the options that are available to run, pass or set up phase play.

Defence :

- ❏ Run in a crouch so that a tackle can be made if attacking players cut back towards the source of possession.

Blind-Side Flanker

Scrums :

- ❏ Work as a unit with the lock to support the prop.
- ❏ Channel the ball to the #8 (loose-head flanker).
- ❏ Push until the ball has left the scrum.
- ❏ Watch the ball as it moves through the scrum.

Lineout (No. 5 position) :

- ❏ Support the # 4 catcher to jump and catch the ball.
- ❏ When the ball is thrown elsewhere, hold the line to prevent opposing players from breaking through.
- ❏ Initiate the drive when the ball is thrown to # 2.

Field Play :

- ❏ Anticipate the position of the ball and move as quickly as possible to that position.
- ❏ Ensure possession is retained by complementing the roles of the players who are at the ball earlier.
- ❏ Choose the best option to maintain continuity.
- ❏ Once one role has been completed move quickly to the next.

Defence :

- ❏ From lineouts move towards the ball and anticipate the ball carrier cutting back so that the player is in a position to make a tackle.
- ❏ From scrums it is difficult to be involved in the front line of defence because the player must be bound until the ball is out. It is better to work out a specified supporting role, similar to that at the lineout.
- ❏ Stop any runners as soon as possible from scrums.
- ❏ When a tackle has been completed or partially completed react to regain possession.

Open-Side Flanker

Scrums :

- ❏ Work as a unit with the lock to support the prop.
- ❏ Channel the ball to number 8 when on the loose-head side..
- ❏ Push until the ball has left the scrum.
- ❏ Watch the ball as it moves through the scrum.

Lineout (No. 7 position).

- ❏ Position close to the opposition on your ball to control the movements of the opposing # 7.
- ❏ Position away from the opposing # 7 on their ball so that the player can run directly towards the opposition backs.
- ❏ Face the opposition.
- ❏ Be further infield than the opposing # 7.
- ❏ Only contest lineout possession from infield of the opposition # 7.

Field Play :

Attack:

- ❏ Be the link player between the backs and the forwards to maintain continuity of play.

Defence :

- ❏ From lineouts move towards the ball and anticipate the ball carrier cutting back to make a tackle. Depending on the defence pattern tackle the first receiver, usually number 10.
- ❏ From scrums the requirement that loose forwards must remain bound until the ball is out will vary the degree to which the flanker can be involved in the first line of defence. As this will depend on a number of factors, amongst them being scrum alignment, the depth of the #10, the length of #'9's passes and the ability of the #7. Flexibility and sound communication during a match can cause the role to vary.
- ❏ Stop any runners as soon as possible from scrums.
- ❏ When a tackle has been completed or partially completed react to retain possession.

No. 8

Scrums :

- ❏ Channel the ball to the right hand side of the scrum so that number 9 is able to pass with minimum interference from opposing players.
- ❏ Position between the loose-head lock and flanker so long as it doesn't disrupt the stability of the scrum.
- ❏ Deliver the ball preferably when the scrum is stable if not moving forward.

Lineout :

- ❏ Be a catching option at number 6. Initiate play around the end of the lineout.
- ❏ Drive forward if possession is gained, especially if in lifting their catchers have left a gap at the back of their lineout.
- ❏ Hold the line when the ball is taken elsewhere in the lineout.

***Field Play** :*

- ❏ Run in support of number 7 (open-side flanker) to ensure continuity of play.

***Defence** :*

- ❏ Scrum – see flankers
- ❏ Lineout - move in support of number 7 to tackle the ball carrier cutting back against the initial movement of the ball.

Halfback / Scrum Half
Passing :

- ❏ Pass to the left or to the right with no back swing and in a single movement. Two-thirds of all passes are made using the left hand as the predominant hand.

- ❏ Place the support leg as close as possible to the ball. This is the right foot when passing to the left and the left foot when passing to the right. However, to protect the ball the passer may turn to pass when passing left. In which case the left foot should be placed close to the ball.

- ❏ Avoid "reaching" away from the body to pick up the ball as this will lead to an unstable body position and it will reduce the power in the pass.

- ❏ Be adaptable - use the pass most appropriate to the situation.

- ❏ Always be in a position before passing so the receiver and the ball can be seen at the same time of vision.

- ❏ Demand that the forwards drive past the line of the ball so that the pass can be made without interference from opponents.

- ❏ Pass a long, yet "sympathetic" pass that can be comfortably caught by the receiver.

Kicking :

- ❏ Move back from the mass of forwards to gain time and space to make an accurate kick.

- ❏ Kick high enough to clear the mass of forwards in front.
- ❏ Be able to make the desired kick while facing in any direction.

- ❏ When kicking over the forwards be conscious of the 10 metre off-side law requirements and actions needed to allow those in front to rejoin play.

- ❏ Judge the success of the box kick by having sufficient time to run forward at good speed and challenge for possession of the ball.

Running :

- ❏ Develop combinations with loose forwards and inside backs.
- ❏ Run infrequently but as the opportunity arises to prevent the defensive loose forwards drifting to assist with defence elsewhere.
- ❏ Run either straight down the field or straight at an opponent Do not drift across the field.
- ❏ Unless a try can be scored seek support before being tackled.

Tactics :

- ❏ Read the game so that decisions are made and action taken without hesitation.
- ❏ Vary the options available based on the game plan so that they complement it.
- ❏ Positionally the halfback is in a very congested area and is instrumental in moving the ball away from congestion.

Playing into the Wind :

- ❏ Develop a range of blind-side skills to control the game in these circumstances.
- ❏ Finally, control your area and be vociferous in organising players in front (the forwards) and immediately behind (the first five-eighth and second five-eighth).

First Five-Eighths / Out Half / Fly Half

Passing :

- ❏ Stand deep but receive as flat as the play will allow.

- ❏ To make a long pass it is an advantage to receive the ball in a stable, standing still position. From this position the long pass can be made more accurately. Stand flatter to ensure that the opposing defenders don't drift and to compensate for not moving onto the ball.

- ❏ Take care to spiral pass only when it is really necessary because the spiral pass is more difficult to catch.

- ❏ For all other passes hip sink pass to prevent the defence from drifting, to gain maximum power and control and to provide the opportunity to make a dummy pass and penetrate through a gap.

Kicking :

- ❏ Kick to "space" unless the height of the kick allows the ball to be regained. Because regaining possession from the opposing teams throw at a lineout is difficult do not kick to touch unless the territory that is gained more than compensates for the loss of possession.

- ❏ Base kicking on the positioning of the defensive backline. If it is flat use the kick but if it is deeper use backline moves to gain territory.

- ❏ Be able to kick accurately while under pressure, using both right and left feet.

Running :

- ❏ Balance running onto the pass to commit the defence with retaining some space and clearing to supporting players who need the space to attack.

- ❏ Use evasive running skills to attack the defence especially from scrums as the loose forwards are less available to defend.

- ❏ When running the blind, over commit the defending players by initially standing flatter on the open side. Run across the back of the scrum so that, before or after receiving the ball, the angle of running is away from and not towards the loose forward defence.

- ❏ Demand correct backline alignment at set pieces and phase play in attack and defence so that the backline can operate as a unit.

Tactics :

- ❏ Choose options that fit in with the team game plan and the tactics that prove successful as the game progresses.

- ❏ If possible choose the tactic to be employed before receiving the ball. This is based on play to this point in the game or on the profile of opponents developed before the match.

- ❏ Communicate the chosen option to those involved in its execution. In the event of disruption to the chosen option make quick decisions to use other options.

- ❏ At breaks in play involve others in decision-making.

- ❏ Attacking options, i.e. when in possession, should take account of the opposing team's defensive behaviour and exploit the best available space.

- ❏ Defensive options, i.e. when not in possession, should be chosen to create uncertainty in the opposing team by reducing their attacking space and options.

***Defence** :*

- ❏ Communicate clearly the pattern to be used.

- ❏ Make the most effective tackle for the situation that takes into account the ball carrier's relative body size.

- ❏ Move into the tackle.

- ❏ Take appropriate action so that attacking plays are stopped as soon as possible.

- ❏ Develop an effective cover defensive role by moving with the ball if it is passed by the designated ball carrier before the player is tackled.

Midfield Backs

Passing :

- ❏ Stand deep but run onto the ball to create maximum commitment from the defence while giving those being passed to time to perform their role.
- ❏ Generally know who the ball is to be passed before receiving it.
- ❏ Make a “sympathetic” pass that gives the receiver options.
- ❏ Pass only to a player who is in a better position.
- ❏ Do not be forced into passing if the area becomes congested. Rather retain possession, stand in the tackle, draw supporting players to the ball and make the transfer hand to hand, reducing the risk of interference.
- ❏ Be able to pass before, in and through the tackle.
- ❏ Make space for the extra player joining an attack by moving into the pass, thus creating space on the outside.

Kicking :

- ❏ The wiper’s kick to the open side is often very successful, especially from scrum possession, because the open side wing has had to move forward to the front line defence.
- ❏ Be aware of the positioning of the opposing blind side wing. This player can often drift across field as an open side attack develops, allowing a kick back towards the blind side to be made.
- ❏ When following and contesting an up and under kick, run just beyond the flight of the ball so that it is being caught while turning with the player’s back to the attacking team’s goal line. This reduces the likelihood of a knock forward. The player should also jump early to catch the ball on the way down. This prevents a defending player from jumping directly up to the ball.

Running :

- ❏ Run straight to give left and right penetrating options.
- ❏ During set moves run predictable lines so that supporting players can perform their roles.
- ❏ Create space for support players by veering left to create space on the right and veering right to create space on the left.
- ❏ Run in balance so that running and passing manoeuvres can be executed successfully.
- ❏ When the defence drifts to defend elsewhere retain possession and penetrate using evasive running skills.
- ❏ When in support as a decoy draw defenders away from the point of penetration.
- ❏ Develop “lanes” when running in support of the ball carrier so that the ball carrier knows where the support is.
- ❏ Be able to vary the pace of running.

Defence :

- ❏ Maintain alignment to prevent defensive gaps so that the whole attack can be seen as it develops.
- ❏ Identify the designated ball carrier and defend that player from the inside.
- ❏ Tackle to prevent territory being gained and, if possible, to regain possession.

Wings

Passing :

- ❏ Develop an in-field pass to support if there is insufficient space on the outside.

- ❏ If opposing players are likely to catch a ball passed in-field use contact skills, e.g. “hit and spin” to move in-field towards supporting players. The ball can then be transferred with greater certainty.

- ❏ When entering a back line as an extra player insist on a pass that is easily caught giving vision of the opposing players.

Kicking :

- ❏ At top pace use the kick ahead and recovery as an attacking ploy.

Running :

- ❏ Stand deep enough for the ball to be received running at close to top pace while retaining maximum vision to assess the options available.

- ❏ Develop a range of individual attacking ploys that can be performed at pace and with stability.

- ❏ Determine the most suitable ploys taking into consideration physical attributes and develop these ploys to a high degree of efficiency.

- ❏ Use supporting players to continue the attack. The more they are used the more unlikely they will make the effort to be available in support.

Tactics :

- ❏ To be an “attacking threat” exploit every opportunity and continually look for work. By being an attacking threat the opposition wing will be held in a defensive position and be unable to enter play elsewhere.

- ❏ More than any other position, the wing must make the game happen by seeking involvement.

- ❏ Once forward momentum has been initiated on attack, use support to keep the movement going. Avoid the touchlines.

***Defence** :*

- ❏ Know the patterns and keep to them because once the ball reaches the attacking wing and the attack is well advanced, the pattern must operate automatically and instinctively.
- ❏ Cover from the blind side with a specific role in mind, e.g. if the fullback has had to move forward to tackle position to catch a kick. Mentally play as the fullback.

Fullbacks

Attack :

- ❏ Enter the backline to make a positive contribution. Don't stand in the backline as an extra pair of hands.

- ❏ When entering the backline on attack make an impact by changing the pace, angle and rhythm of the attack. Do not enter if an extra pair of hands is going to slow the attack.

- ❏ Enter the line as late and as unexpectedly as possible.

- ❏ Do not stand in the gap that is to be run into prior to play starting.

- ❏ The pass should give the fullback three receiving options :
    - Close to the ball carrier
    - In the gap
    - Drifting out with the ball to an outside gap

- ❏ Be deep enough to sum up the options.

Defence :

- ❏ Determine the pattern for the back three, set it early and if necessary "talk" it into place as the attack develops.

- ❏ Be positive in making the tackle, make the move early to reduce the opposing player's reaction time.

- ❏ Generally encourage a ball carrier to take an outside break so that the touchline can be used as a defensive boundary. If the player is outnumbered, maintain a defensive position so the pass is delayed, giving time for support to arrive.

- ❏ Adjust your position to suit the playing conditions and the position of the set play on the field.

- ❏ With confidence, "imagined" gaps can be left, "conning" the opposing players to kick into them. This enables a skilful player to predict the position the kick will be made to allowing the ball to be moved into and regained.

- ❏ Rather than be caught standing under the ball flat-footed, such a move enables the fullback to run to the ball, catch it and move away. The fullback is more difficult to tackle when moving and can leap into the air to catch the high ball.

Step Four

Analysis of Players

In Step Four the player profile forms that were used in Step One are used in more detail. Here they are used to rank players by position. The ranking will be based on the positional requirements.

So long as there has been sufficient effort to ensure that the Team Profile and the Game Plan are accurate then the positional requirements will be accurate. The players will therefore be judged by what is needed to be successful.

The player profile forms should be regularly updated. They can be used to follow the players progress during the season. By ranking players according to the position based on the information on the forms, the selectors are in a position to make an initial selection.

The ranking also gives the selectors a “pecking order” should first choices be injured or if more than one team has to be selected from the same pool of players.

Step Five

Selection Responsibilities

Once the players have been ranked and the rankings received throughout the selection period players can be categorised into three groups - “in”, “out” and “unsure”.

- ❑ The “in” players are those who will definitely be in the team.
- ❑ The “out” players are those who will definitely not be in the team.
- ❑ The “unsure” players are those who the selectors are unsure of and who will be competing with each other to make the team.

This method enables the selectors to concentrate on the last group, the “unsure” players. Their task is now more manageable and selecting can become more specific.

The convenor will now be able to delegate responsibility to members of the panel.

The player requirements will now become very specific so that the minor differences between players of equal calibre can be identified.

Step Six

Observing Games

When selectors are watching players they must be constantly referring to the positional requirements they are to concentrate on. This task is different from coaching. The selectors are watching individual players. They should not be distracted from this by watching the match as a whole. This takes considerable discipline.

Experience has shown that individual players should be watched constantly for up to 10 minutes. This would seem to be the minimum period. The selector must be able to observe play away from the ball as well as play when the player is directly involved in using, retaining or regaining the ball. This is more important for some positions than others.

When a selector is watching a player the positional requirements are a checklist to categorise information. All information should be recorded. This may be done by writing it down, however, play can be missed while this is being done. A better method is to use a dictaphone. This can be replayed a number of times after the match.

Both written notes and recorded information must be compared to the positional requirements. This ensures that each player for each position is compared using the same criteria. Selectors should watch players independently. This is to ensure they don't fall into the trap of supporting each others point of view.

A major difficulty when selecting is reducing the number of players being watched so each can be watched for some time. The categorisation of players into the "in", "out" and "unsure" groups achieve this. It enables selectors to concentrate on a limited number. This is a worthwhile method, however problems arise when players take part in trials.

Prior to the naming of trial teams a considerable amount of work will have to be done gathering information on players. In a trial, comparisons can be made between two players competing for the same position. The difficulty is that there are 15 positions, all of which may have to be observed. Clearly this is impossible to do thoroughly. This can be helped by playing against an opposing team that is not in contention for selection. It reduces the number of players to be watched by half, but it is difficult to make comparisons.

At representative level and above, the problem may be solved by increasing the number of selectors for the trials only. The most obvious way would be to have a selector for each position. This would involve eleven selectors. Where there are two players playing in a position there will still be time enough to watch each player for at least 10 minutes. This frees the official selection panel to watch individual players as they will know that there are selectors covering all positions.

For this to work successfully, the positional selectors have to be briefed in detail about the positional requirements. Once the trial is over a debriefing of the whole group should take place before the official panel is left to make their final selection.

This system works well so long as the positional selectors are well chosen, understand what is required and are disciplined to watch the players rather than the match. When this is first done, all positional selectors may not be able to meet these criteria. However, at each successive trial the standard will improve as they become familiar with what is required. Changes may have to be made before someone who is good at positional selecting is found.

Step Seven

Selection Meetings

Regular selection meetings are essential to monitor the development of players. There are two types of selection meetings. Those that take place prior to the selection of the team and those that take place once the team has been selected.

Pre-Selection Meetings

At the first meeting the ranking lists of players by position mentioned in Step Four - Analysis of Players should be written down. By doing this the panel has a starting point for selection. Considerable time should be spent discussing the merits of individual players before ranking them. This ranking should be reviewed at each meeting that follows. Changes must be justified.

These meetings have two further functions. The first is to categorise the players into the “in”, “out” and “unsure” groups. The second is to identify players who need to be watched more frequently because the selectors have insufficient current information about them.

If positional selectors are used at trials they should be asked for their rank order and they must give their reasons for it. They must be prepared to be questioned by the selection panel about their rankings.

These meetings will highlight strengths and weaknesses. Because of this they may have to revise aims, Game Plan and Patterns of Play. Secondly, they will be able to focus on positional weaknesses. This may force them to select beyond the initial group of players, to cast their net wider.

Post Selection Meetings

Post selection meetings are those that take place after the team has been selected. They are therefore meetings that take place during the teams playing season. They will usually take place as soon as possible after a match to select the teams for the next match. It may not be possible to spend time discussing rankings each week. In fact this may lead to erratic selections that will prevent the team establishing its patterns of play as a unit. Ranking meetings should be scheduled to take place less frequently but regularly.

At meetings between each game it is most important to know of injuries to players. It is important that a realistic assessment of the injury is made. The player should return to play only after total rehabilitation. It is equally important to ensure that the player is following a course of treatment that will ensure a return to play as soon as possible.

When teams are being selected it is important to justify changes to the initially selected teams. For a change to be made the replacement player must have been consistently better than the incumbent. If this is not the case, a change made and the change is unsuccessful, two players will have had their confidence affected and the performance of the team will have been detrimentally affected.

Step Eight

Priorities and Consistency

It may be worthwhile when selecting to have a prioritised order of selecting. This order would state what should be the first priority, second priority and so on.

Selecting to a Game Plan using the ranking system based on positional requirements to meet the Game Plan directs the selection panel to its own list of priorities. While the priorities for selection must always be subjective, the following may be useful for selectors in determining their own:

Priority	Selection Criteria
1	**Points scoring ability.**
2	Possession winning ability.
3	**Ability to maintain continuity.**
4	**Decision-making ability (consistency).**
5	**Ability to perform basic attacking and defensive skills.**

Whatever method is used, the most important element of any selection method is consistency.

So that the Game develops within a national union, a provincial union, a club or a school, the selection policy must reflect the Game Plan that has been developed. Consistency is therefore the most important priority in ensuring the Game develops.

For this reason it may be necessary to meet with all coaches and selectors and some players to work together on the Game Plan. By involving all in the formation of the Game Plan they will feel committed to it. They must all be made to feel that they are part of the whole and not a number of parts belonging to individual teams.

Step Nine

Attitude

Players competing for a position may be of equal ability. The strengths and weaknesses of a player may be matched by different strengths and weaknesses of another. Selection in these circumstances will be based on which player fulfils the demands of the Game Plan.

But if the players still offer equal ability, the final criteria should be attitude. Even within this category are a number of criteria e.g. :

- **commitment**
- **determination**
- **composure**
- **reliability**
- **concentration**
- **persistence**
- **compatibility**
- **initiative**

Selectors will know the value they may place on each of these. The emphasis should reflect what is needed by the team in that position.This will vary from position to position. However, it is likely that the attitude criteria for a position will be similar, if not the same.

Step Ten

Intuition

It is at this stage after the situation has been thoroughly analysed in a systematic way that the selectors' intuition becomes important.

We are dealing with a situation that involves people who are not robots. Because of this no selection can be entirely correct or entirely wrong. In a competitive situation the reaction of players will vary from match to match.

After watching players for a long time, the selector will develop a feeling for the play of the player. The final selection will be based on the selector backing this feeling.

Conclusion

Selectors must be able to justify their selections to the players. This information allows players to identify their weaknesses, those factors that result in their non-selection, so that they can work on them.

Unless selection is carried out systematically, the selector's advice to the players will be vague and general. This will detrimentally affect the selector's credibility.

During the season team changes will occur. A player who has been replaced should have been told what is expected prior to a match and what the faults were after the match. In these circumstances the player will know why their replacement has occurred. It should not be spontaneous and unexpected. Players replace themselves by not performing the positional requirements to the required standard.

The player must be able to accept the selector's point of view. The player may disagree with the view, however, the credibility of the selector lies in his willingness to tell the player what is required, what has not been achieved and to tell the player prior to anyone else knowing. The player has the right to know of non-selection before anyone else outside the selection panel and where possible, they should be told face-to-face, not on the telephone and through the media.

This aspect of selecting is the most difficult. To reduce the effect of these difficulties, the selection process must be systematic, the player should be dealt with honestly and when the change occurs it must be handled personally and immediately. Selectors must be prepared to be personally responsible for their own action.

Reference

The section on Player profiling and Selection was from:

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Player Profiling and Selection (Lee Smith)